

Plex Metadata Transfer Guide: Mac to Windows

The Problem

Copying video files from a Mac Plex server to a Windows Plex server causes hours of scanning and metadata downloading, especially problematic with slow internet at the remote location.

The Solution

Copy the Plex database and metadata from your Mac (home) to Windows (remote) so Plex doesn't need to rescan or redownload anything.

Your Setup

- **Home (Mac):** Master Plex server
 - Videos: `/volume/macexternal/plexserver/videos`
 - TV Shows: `/volume/macexternal/plexserver/series`
 - **Remote (Windows):** Secondary Plex server
 - Videos: `D:\videos`
 - TV Shows: `D:\series`
 - D: drive is portable (carried between locations)
 - **Remote Access:** Jump Desktop configured to home Mac
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Step-by-Step Workflow

At Home (Mac)

1. **Stop the Plex server**
 2. **Copy these folders to your D: drive** (create a temp folder like `D:\plex_transfer`):
 - `~/Library/Application Support/Plex Media Server/Metadata`
 - `~/Library/Application Support/Plex Media Server/Media`
 - `~/Library/Application Support/Plex Media Server/Plug-in Support/Databases`
 3. **Optional but recommended:** Compress these folders first to reduce size from ~6GB to ~3-4GB
 4. **Restart your home Plex server**
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At Remote (Windows)

1. **Stop the Plex server** (if running)
2. **Copy the folders from D: drive to:**

`C:\Users\YourUsername\AppData\Local\Plex Media Server`

Replace/merge the existing Metadata, Media, and Databases folders

3. Edit the database to fix file paths:

- Download and install [DB Browser for SQLite](#)
- **IMPORTANT: Make a backup** of this file first:

```
C:\Users\[YourUsername]\AppData\Local\Plex Media Server\Plug-in  
Support\Databases\com.plexapp.plugins.library.db
```

- Open the `(.db)` file in DB Browser
- Go to "Execute SQL" tab
- Run these commands:

```
sql  
  
UPDATE media_parts  
SET file = REPLACE(file, '/volume/macexternal/plexserver/videos', 'D:/videos');  
  
UPDATE media_parts  
SET file = REPLACE(file, '/volume/macexternal/plexserver/series', 'D:/series');
```

4. Click "Write Changes" and close DB Browser
5. **Start the Plex server**
6. **Verify in Plex:**
 - Go to Settings → Manage → Libraries
 - Click "Scan Library Files" on each library
 - Should complete almost instantly

Alternative: Speed Up Regular Scanning

If you don't want to copy metadata, at least disable these heavy features before scanning:

1. Settings → Manage → Libraries → Edit library → Advanced tab
2. **Uncheck:**
 - Generate video preview thumbnails
 - Generate chapter thumbnails
 - Enable intro detection

This reduces scan time from hours to 30-60 minutes for most libraries.

Remote Transfer Option (If Needed)

If you're already at the remote site and need the metadata:

1. **Via Jump Desktop:** Connect to your Mac
2. **Stop Plex** on the Mac
3. **Compress the 3 folders** (right-click → Compress)
4. **Upload to cloud storage** (Google Drive, Dropbox, etc.)
5. **Download at remote** (will be slow with bad internet, but still better than Plex downloading all metadata)
6. **Follow the Windows steps above**

Note: With very slow remote internet, this could take a long time but is still faster than letting Plex download metadata for your entire library.

Current Situation Recommendation

Given your ancient Surface 3 machine and terrible remote internet:

Best approach: Wait for the Surface Go setup

- Don't torture the Surface 3
 - Set up Plex fresh on Surface Go when ready
 - Do ONE scan with heavy features disabled
 - Next time home, implement this metadata transfer workflow
 - Future updates will be instant
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Troubleshooting

Plex won't stop scanning:

- Open Task Manager (Ctrl+Shift+Esc)
- Find "Plex Media Server" processes
- End Task on all of them
- If machine is frozen, restart computer

Libraries show as empty after database edit:

- Check your SQL paths match exactly: `(D:/videos)` not `(D:\videos)` (forward slashes)
- Verify files actually exist at those paths on D: drive
- Restore database backup and try again

Database file is locked:

- Make sure Plex server is completely stopped
 - Check Task Manager for any lingering Plex processes
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Notes

- Database size: ~6GB (Metadata + Media + Databases combined)
- Use forward slashes (/) in SQL even for Windows paths
- Always backup the database before editing
- The portable D: drive carries both media files and metadata transfer folders